



How to Use Your Detailing Kit

EVERY PRODUCT & TOOL ON THE SHOPPING LIST — WHAT IT'S FOR, HOW TO USE IT

GOLDEN RULES — READ FIRST

- Wheels & tires first — they're the dirtiest part of the car.
- Two buckets, grit guards, separate mitts — that's how you avoid swirls.
- Let products dwell — don't scrub off a remover before it works.
- Color-code towels and keep glass/wax/interior cloths apart.
- Always work top-to-bottom outside, cleanest-to-dirtiest inside.
- Work in the shade; never apply products to hot paint.
- Use less product than you think; thin layers buff off easy.
- Decontaminate (iron + clay) before any wax, sealant or coating.

1 Wash & exterior

pH-neutral car shampoo

USE Safe routine washing that won't strip wax or sealant.

HOW Dilute per label into your wash bucket or foam cannon; wash top-to-bottom, then rinse.

Never use dish soap — it strips your protection and dries out trim.

Two-bucket wash kit (+ grit guards)

USE Keeping grit off your mitt so you don't scratch the paint.

HOW One bucket soap, one rinse. After each panel, rinse the mitt and scrub it on the grit guard before reloading with soap.

Add a third bucket used only for wheels.

Microfiber wash mitts

USE Lifting dirt with the least marring.

HOW Use one mitt for upper panels and a separate, dirtier one for lower panels.

Drop it on the ground? Rinse it before it touches paint again.

Bug & tar / sap remover

USE Dissolving baked-on bugs, tar and tree sap.

HOW Spray on a cool panel, dwell 1–2 min, agitate gently, then wash off.

Work in shade and don't let it dry on the paint.

Iron / fallout remover

USE Dissolving embedded brake dust and industrial fallout before claying.

HOW Spray on a cool, washed panel; it bleeds purple as it reacts. Dwell, then rinse fully.

Strong smell — work ventilated and rinse completely.

Clay bar kit + lube

USE Pulling bonded contaminants the wash leaves behind (paint feels gritty).

HOW Spray lube generously and glide the clay flat with light pressure until smooth; fold to a clean face often.

If you drop the clay, bin it — trapped grit will scratch.

Drying towels (twist-loop / waffle)

USE Streak-free drying without swirls.

HOW Blot and drag lightly; finish with a second dry towel.

Wash separately, never with fabric softener.

2 Wheels, tires & trim

Acid-free wheel cleaner

USE Safely cleaning every wheel finish.

HOW Rinse the wheel, spray cleaner, agitate with brushes, then rinse.

Do wheels first while the body soaks — and never on a hot wheel.

Wheel woolies / brushes

USE Reaching barrels, spokes and lug areas.

HOW Match brush size to the gap; use gentle pressure.

Keep wheel brushes separate from your paint tools.

Tire & wheel-well scrub brush

USE Scrubbing brown off tires and grime out of wells.

HOW Stiff brush with APC or wheel cleaner; scrub and rinse.

Clean tires fully or your shine won't last.

Tire shine / dressing + applicators

USE The finished black tire look.

HOW Apply thin and even to a clean, dry tire with an applicator; wipe the excess.

Wipe the edge to stop sling onto your fresh paint.

Trim / plastic restorer

USE Restoring faded grey exterior plastic trim.

HOW Apply to clean, dry trim, let it cure, then buff lightly.

| *Tape adjacent paint when using a strong dressing.*

Wheel sealant

USE Making wheels easier to clean and resist brake dust.

HOW Apply thin to a clean, dry wheel; let cure; buff off.

| *Only ever on a freshly cleaned wheel.*

3 Glass

Ammonia-free glass cleaner

USE Streak-free windows that are safe on tint.

HOW Spray onto the towel (not the glass in sun), wipe, then flip and buff dry.

| *Ammonia damages window tint — keep it ammonia-free.*

Waffle-weave glass towels

USE Streak-free finishing on glass.

HOW One towel to clean, a second dry one to buff.

| *Keep glass towels separate — wax residue causes streaks.*

4 Interior

Wet/dry vacuum

USE Seats, carpets, mats and crevices.

HOW Crevice tool for seams, brush head for panels; go slow.

| *Agitate carpet with a brush first to lift embedded dirt.*

Carpet extractor

USE Deep-cleaning fabric and pulling the dirt back out.

HOW Spray or inject solution, agitate, then extract until the water runs clear.

| *Don't over-wet — dry with fans to avoid mildew.*

All-purpose cleaner (APC)

USE General interior surfaces, mats and door panels.

HOW Dilute (stronger for carpet, weaker for soft plastics); spray onto a brush, agitate, wipe.

| *Test a hidden spot first; never strong APC on real leather.*

Interior brushes + swabs

USE Vents, seams, buttons and stitching.

HOW Use dry or with a little APC; soft brush for delicate trim, swabs for vent slats.

| *A soft brush prevents scuffing glossy piano-black trim.*

Carpet / upholstery shampoo

USE Extractor cleaning of fabric seats and carpet.

HOW Use in the extractor, or spray, agitate and extract.

| *Pre-treat stains before the main pass.*

5 Polish, correction & protection

Dual-action (DA) polisher

USE Machine correction and safely applying products.

HOW Spread on low speed, then work section-by-section at medium speed with light overlapping passes.

| *DA is beginner-safe — keep the pad flat and never dwell in one spot.*

Backing plates + pads

USE Matching pad aggressiveness to the job.

HOW Cutting pad + compound for defects, polishing pad to refine, soft/finishing pad for wax & sealant.

| *Swap pads often — a clogged pad stops cutting.*

Plastic / vinyl conditioner

USE Protecting and restoring dash and door plastics.

HOW Wipe onto an applicator, spread on, then buff off the excess.

| *Choose matte — glossy dressings cause windshield glare and attract dust.*

Leather cleaner + conditioner

USE Cleaning then feeding leather seats.

HOW Clean with leather cleaner and a soft brush, wipe, then condition and buff.

| *Never use APC on real leather — it dries and cracks it.*

Enzyme odor eliminator

USE Killing odor sources (pet, smoke, spills).

HOW Spray onto the source and let it dwell; treat the A/C through the vents.

| *It digests the smell — give it time instead of just masking.*

Microfiber towels (color-coded)

USE Everything — color-coding stops cross-contamination.

HOW Assign colors by zone, e.g. blue = glass, green = interior, yellow = wax/paint.

| *Wash separately, no softener — it kills absorbency.*

Cutting compound

USE Removing swirls and light scratches (one-step correction).

HOW A few drops on a cutting pad; work a small section until it clears, then wipe.

| *Start with the least aggressive combo that works.*

Finishing polish

USE Refining gloss after compounding.

HOW On a polishing pad, light passes, then wipe.

| *Essential on dark colors to clear compound haze/hologramming.*

Carnauba wax

USE Warm, glossy protection lasting weeks to months.

HOW Thin even layer with an applicator, let it haze, then buff off.

| *Less is more — thick wax is miserable to buff.*

Paint sealant / ceramic spray

USE Longer-lasting protection (months).

HOW Sealant: apply thin, cure, buff. Ceramic spray: mist on, spread, buff to clarity.

| *Only bonds properly to decontaminated paint.*

Ceramic coating kit

USE Durable protection (1–5 years).

HOW Correct & panel-wipe first; apply with a suede block in a cross-hatch, let it flash, then level off.

| *Work in shade in small sections; keep it dry 24 h and don't leave high spots.*

6 Add-on specials

Rubber pet brush / pumice

USE Dragging embedded pet hair out of fabric.

HOW Drag in one direction to ball the hair up, vacuum, then repeat.

| *A damp rubber glove works in a pinch.*

Headlight restoration kit

USE Clearing yellowed, hazy headlights.

HOW Mask around the lens, wet-sand coarse → fine, polish clear, then apply the UV sealant.

| *The UV sealant is the key step — skip it and the haze returns fast.*

7 Mobile rig

Portable water tank + pump

USE Bringing your own water to every job.

HOW Fill before the day; the pump feeds your pressure washer or hose.

| *Budget ~40–60 gal per full detail.*

Pressure washer + foam cannon

USE Rinsing and a foam pre-wash.

HOW Foam-soak the car to soften dirt before you ever touch it, then rinse.

| *Keep the nozzle back from paint and trim; never a zero-degree tip on paint.*

Rinseless / waterless wash

USE Washing where runoff is restricted (driveways, lots).

HOW Rinseless: dilute in a bucket, wipe a panel, flip. Waterless: spray and wipe lightly-soiled cars.

| *Light dirt only — heavy grime still needs a proper rinse.*

8 PPE & shop supplies

Nitrile gloves

USE Protecting your hands from chemicals.

HOW Wear during wheel, decon, correction and coating work.

| *Keep a box in the van — they tear, you'll restock often.*

Panel-prep / IPA wipe

USE Stripping polishing oils so you see true results and coatings bond.

HOW Spray on, wipe, then flip to a dry side.

| *Non-negotiable before any sealant or coating.*

Coating applicator blocks + suede

USE Laying coatings down evenly.

HOW Wrap suede on the block, add a few drops, apply in a cross-hatch.

| *Toss the cloth once it stiffens — a hard cloth scratches.*

LED inspection light

USE Seeing defects and checking your work.

HOW Hold at angles in the shade to reveal swirls, holograms and coating high spots.

| *Check after every correction and coating step.*

Engine degreaser + dressing

USE Cleaning and finishing the engine bay.

HOW Cool engine, cover electronics, degrease, agitate, low-pressure rinse, dry, then dress.

| *Never blast electrical connectors with high pressure.*

Undercarriage / salt neutralizer

USE Winter salt and road grime under the car.

HOW Flush the wells and underside, apply neutralizer, dwell, then rinse.

| *Critical through winter to hold off rust.*

Portable power (generator / battery)

USE Running the vacuum, extractor and polisher off-grid.

HOW Size it to your highest-wattage tool plus headroom.

| *A battery power station is quieter for residential jobs.*

Hose reel, nozzles & cords

USE Fast, tidy setup and teardown.

HOW Reel hoses and cords after every job so the rig is ready to roll.

| *Tangled lines are lost minutes on every booking.*

Kneeling pad / knee pads

USE Saving your knees on wheels, lower panels and interiors.

HOW Drop it wherever you're working low.

| *Cheap insurance against a long day's aches.*

Labeled spray & dilution bottles

USE Pre-mixing dilutions and avoiding mix-ups.

HOW Mix to label ratios and clearly mark each bottle.

Label the dilution ratio too, not just the product.

Painter's tape

USE Masking trim, badges and edges before machine work.

HOW Tape off anything you don't want compound or coating on.

Pull tape before it bakes in the sun.

Microfiber detergent + mesh bags

USE Making your towels last.

HOW Wash microfiber on its own with proper detergent; bag delicate ones.

No fabric softener — ever. It ruins absorbency.

Trash bags, caddy, first-aid kit

USE Job-site basics.

HOW Bag interior trash first; keep tools in a caddy and a first-aid kit on board.

A tidy rig looks professional to the customer watching.
